

The Marrow-Thief's Bakehouse

A Level 3 Promotional One-Shot for *The Carrion Knead*

This adventure is designed to be played in a single 3-4 hour session. It serves as a perfect introduction to the culinary horror of The Carrion Knead, giving players a taste of Gastromancy and ending with a direct narrative hook into Tier 1 of the full campaign.

Adventure Background

For the past month, a traveling merchant named **Silas the Sweet** has parked his iron-wheeled baker's wagon at the crossroads outside a sleepy frontier village. His pastries are legendary—meat pies that cure diseases, and sourdough loaves that grant unearthly stamina.

But there is a dark secret. Silas is a rogue Gastromancer, rejected by the monstrous covens of the Sweetmeat Maw for being too sloppy. He has been abducting lonely travelers on the road, grinding their bones into "Soul-Flour," and baking them into his miraculous treats.

The Hook

The party is hired by the local magistrate to investigate a string of missing travelers. All of them vanished near the crossroads. The magistrate offers 100 gold pieces for any information leading to their safe return.

Part 1: The Iron-Wheeled Wagon

When the players arrive at the crossroads, they find Silas's wagon—a massive, black-iron carriage with a smoking chimney. The air smells aggressively of roasted garlic, browned butter, and... copper.

Silas the Sweet (use *Cult Fanatic* stats) greets them warmly. He is a sweaty, jittery man with flour covering his hands. * If questioned about the missing travelers, he deflects, offering the party a free **Marrow-Puff Pastry** (Heals 2d8 HP, but the eater must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom save or suffer terrible nightmares of being eaten alive during their next long rest). * A **DC 14 Perception check** reveals the flour on his apron has a faint greyish, calcified tint to it. * A **DC 15 Investigation check** around the back of the wagon reveals fresh blood and drag

marks leading to a heavy iron storm-cellar door hidden under a tarp.

Part 2: The Root Cellar of Horrors

If the players break into the cellar (DC 13 Thieves' Tools) or force Silas to open it, they descend into a makeshift underground abattoir.

Encounter: The Sourdough Homunculi

The cellar is suffocatingly hot, filled with bubbling vats of yeast. Suspended from the ceiling are the flayed remains of the missing travelers. As the party enters, the vats burst open!

- **Encounter: 4 Sourdough Homunculi** (Use *Mud Mephit* stats, but replace their breath weapon with a *Boiling Yeast Spray* that deals Acid damage).
 - **Hazard:** The floor is slick with grease. Any creature moving more than 15 feet in a turn must make a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw or fall prone.
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Part 3: The Marrow-Thief

Hearing the commotion, Silas locks the cellar door from the outside and pours a bucket of animated, glowing purple **Synaptic Glaze** down the stairs before leaping down to kill the intruders.

Boss Fight: Silas & The Glazed Ooze

- **Silas the Sweet:** AC 14, 45 HP. He wields a heavy iron rolling pin (1d8+2 bludgeoning) and can cast *Burning Hands* (flavored as a spray of boiling cooking oil).
- **The Synaptic Glaze Ooze:** Use *Gray Ooze* stats. It deals psychic damage instead of acid, and any player hit by it hears the screaming thoughts of the people baked into the pastries.

Loot: Defeating Silas yields 120 gp, a *Wand of Create Food and Water* (made from a human femur), and his prized recipe book.

The Conclusion & The Hook

Hidden in the back page of Silas's recipe book is a bloodstained letter sealed with dark wax.

"Silas. Your sloppy work draws too much attention from the village guards. If you want to learn true Gastromancy—if you want to bake bread that can command the dead—leave your petty cart and come to The Weeping Willow Inn in the valley of Bleak Hollow. Show this letter to Mother Gristle, and the oven doors will open to you."

— Harkon the Lean

GM Note to the Players: *If you survived the horrors of the Marrow-Thief, the true nightmare is just beginning. What horrors await at the Weeping Willow Inn? Find out in The Carrion Knead, a 1-20 Grimdark Gastromancy Campaign. Back it on Kickstarter today!*